

Happy prince

The story "The Happy Prince" is a moral and social [allegory](#) in that it places shallowness vs. altruism; idleness vs. sacrifice; and contempt vs. compassion under the perspective of the one person who once was adored by all and now has a statue made after him: The so-called Happy Prince.

Once, when the Prince was alive, he was filled with richness and opulence to the point that, after his death, he was made into a statue of gold leaf and jewels. After the shallow swallow visits him and does the favor of giving one of the statue's rubies to a poor person, the Prince demonstrates that, as he gives more and more of his jewels and disrobes himself from the gold, he gains more for feeding the poor and clothing the needy thanks to the riches in his statue.

Slowly, as the swallow continues to deliver the goods of the statue to the poor of the city, he learns the social imbalance that exists in society, where some have too much and others too little. In the case of Wilde's time, Victorian England was experiencing the same inequity in the slum districts and Oscar's story is a clear allegory and [metaphor](#) of the British Social System at the time: Where the rich were filthy rich and the poor starved to death.

In the end, the swallow learns the lesson, the prince is completely run down from the jewels and gold that decorated him and, in accordance to the typical Victorian mentality, he was not worth attention anymore because, as the story says:

"As he is no longer beautiful he is no longer useful,'

Hence, the shallowness of the people ended up with them trying to destroy the statue, the swallow dies next to it, and both go to Heaven where God deems them two beautiful creations just because of being who they are.

Early commentators on the story saw this as merely another tale of terror or horror in which something supernatural was happening. To the modern reader, it is less ambiguous; the beating of the heart occurs within the narrator himself. It is established at the beginning of the story that he is over-sensitive — that he can hear and feel things that others cannot. At the end of the story, if there really were a beating heart up under the floor boards, then the police would have heard it. Clearly,

the narrator, who has just finished the gruesome act of dismembering a corpse, cannot cope with the highly emotional challenge needed when the police are searching the house. These two factors cause his heart rate to accelerate to the point that his heartbeat is pounding in his ears so loudly that he cannot stand the psychological pressure any longer. Thus he confesses to his horrible deed. The narrator's "tell-tale" heart causes him to convict himself.

We have here, then, a narrator who believes that he is *not* mad because he can logically describe events which *seem* to prove him to be mad. The conciseness of the story and its intensity and economy all contribute to the total impact and the overall unity of effect. In the narrator's belief that he is not mad, but that he actually heard the heart of the old man still beating, Poe has given us one of the most powerful examples of the capacity of the human mind to deceive itself and then to speculate on the nature of its own destruction.

Far from offering Huck any kind of freedom from his strictly “sivilized” lifestyle, Pap imposes yet another kind of imprisonment, one based on class, where Huck is prevented from bettering and educating himself. This is counter-intuitive: Pap should want the best for his son, but he instead wants no better for Huck than what he himself had.

Literary Periods – Overview

The Romantic Age c 1800-1835

Focuses on the love of nature and the importance of beauty, folk tradition, medieval tales of knights and damsels in distress. All this partly as a reaction to the Industrial Revolution, the Age of Enlightenment and other examples on increasing modernity. Typical features that frequently occur in literature from the period is powerful love, unreturned love, rivals in love, strong emotions (hate, fear), darkness, gloom and doom, mystery and in the case of the gothic literature, the supernatural.

Examples of writers: Jane Austen, Mary Shelley, Edgar Allen Poe, Matthew Lewis (the last three examples of writers of gothic novels).

Gothic novels e.g. Mary Shelley's Frankenstein, Edgar Allan Poe, Bram Stoker's Dracula

The Victorian Age c 1837-1901

A gradual move from Romantic novel to Realism, describing life as it really is without idealization or romantic subjectivity, often of the poor.

Main characteristics:

- Faithful representation of life
- Concentrating on middle-class life and preoccupations
- Scenes of humble life
- Criticism of social conditions
- Characters are in centre of interest as opposed to a plot
- Subjects portrayed with simplicity and respect but little elaboration
- Honest, matter-of-fact style
- Objects or figures are represented impartially and objectively

Examples of writers: Charles Dickens, Oscar Wilde, George Bernard Shaw, Rudyard Kipling, The Bronte sisters

Realism 1820-1920

A move towards depictions of contemporary life and society as it was, or is, paying a lot of attention to the details of everyday life. It was also a reaction to the changes that occurred in society, an effect of the industrialization and the harsh conditions of the working class. It was also influenced by the invention of photography, i.e. to be able to capture exactly how things looked. It was predominantly a movement led by people from the middle class, attempting to throw a light on the misery of the working class

Examples of writers; Mark Twain, George Eliot, Gustave Flaubert

Modernism c 1910-1965

Modernist literature was a predominantly English genre of fiction writing, popular from roughly the 1910s into the 1960s. Modernist literature came into its own due to increasing industrialization and globalization. New technology and the horrifying events of both World Wars (but specifically World War I) made many people question the future of humanity: What was becoming of the world?

Writers reacted to this question by turning toward Modernist sentiments. Gone was the Romantic period that focused on nature and being. Modernist fiction spoke of the inner self and consciousness. Instead of progress, the Modernist writer saw a decline of civilization. Instead of new technology, the Modernist writer saw cold machinery and increased capitalism, which alienated the individual and led to loneliness.

To achieve the emotions described above, most Modernist fiction was cast in first person. Whereas earlier, most literature had a clear beginning, middle, and end (or introduction, conflict, and

resolution), the Modernist story was often more of a *stream of consciousness*. Irony, satire, and comparisons were often employed to point out society's ills.

Experimentation with genre and form

Examples of writers: T.S. Eliot, Virginia Woolf, James Joyce, William Faulkner, F Scott Fitzgerald, Ernest Hemingway, Sylvia Plath

The Beat Generation 1945-1965

Allen Ginsberg

Jack Keroac